

Ouroborus cataphractus

Armadillo lizard



Length 6½–8½ in (16–21 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location Southern Africa

The armadillo lizard is covered with stout, defensive spines on its neck and tail and squarish scales on its back. When threatened, it grasps its tail in its mouth and forms a ring with its body, presenting the spines to deter an approaching predator and making it awkward to attack. Armadillo lizards occur in scrub and rocky outcrops, hiding in large cracks, and hibernating in winter. They live

in family groups—the female gives birth to one or 2 large young, and may even feed them—a characteristic that is unusual among lizards, which rarely demonstrate parental care. Insects and spiders make up most of the diet of the armadillo lizard and it, in turn, is hunted by a variety of predators, including birds of prey. It can live for up to 25 years in captivity, slightly more in some exceptional cases.

Cordylus giganteus

Sungazer



Length 11–15½ in (28–39 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location Southern Africa

Also known as the giant girdled lizard, the yellowish to dark brown sungazer can often be seen basking at the entrance to its burrow, apparently staring at the sun. Burrows usually face north or northwest, providing maximum sunshine throughout the day. This lizard possesses an armored tail, ringed with pointed scales and resembling a pinecone, which it can use to block the entrance to its burrow. If grasped, it wedges the long spines on its head and neck into the burrow roof, making its body difficult to extract. Its diet consists of insects and small vertebrates. Females give birth to one or 2 young, which remain near the adults. The sungazer hibernates during the winter months.

Cordylus rhodesianus

Zimbabwe girdled lizard



Length 4¾–6¾ in (12–17 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Southern Africa

This olive-brown lizard is often found in kopjes—the piles of eroded rock that are scattered across southern Africa's grasslands. Its flattened body enables it to hide in narrow cracks or under rocks when threatened, and it uses its tail, which is covered in rings of pointed scales, to block the cracks and deter predators such as snakes, birds, and mammals. The Zimbabwe girdled lizard lives in small family groups—with the young remaining near the parents—and hibernates in winter.

Gerrhosaurus major

Rough-scaled plated lizard



Length 16–19 in (40–48 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location C., E., and southern Africa

The body of the rough-scaled plated lizard is covered with rectangular plates, arranged in rows, that help the reptile

wedge itself into cracks in rocky outcrops for protection against birds of prey, snakes, and small mammals. This lizard is light to medium brown, but the male develops a pinkish throat in the breeding season. An active forager, its diet comprises fruit,

flowers, invertebrates, and small vertebrates, including smaller lizards. The male is highly territorial, particularly during the breeding season, when he fights with other males. The female lays 2–4 relatively large, oval eggs in rock crevices, in moist soil, and under logs.

Platysaurus broadleyi

Broadley's flat lizard



Length 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Southern Africa (Augrabies Falls)

The extremely flattened head, body, and tail of this lizard enable it to squeeze into very narrow rock crevices to escape from predatory birds of prey, particularly the rock kestrel.

Once wedged in, it is almost impossible to extract. This lizard spends most of the day hunting for insects, especially the small black flies that swarm near waterfalls, darting rapidly to catch the flies when they land, or leaping upward to catch them in flight. It also eats ripe berries. The male has a bluish head, green back, yellow or orange front limbs, and an orange-tan tail. The female and juveniles have dark brown backs with 3 cream stripes and a pale yellow tail. The female lays 2 clutches of 2 eggs each summer, in deep cracks between large

boulders and under exfoliating flakes of rock, especially where leaves or debris have accumulated.

Lacerta agilis

Sand lizard



Length 7–9 in (18–22 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location Europe to C. Asia

This stocky lizard belongs to a group of species that are common in Europe and Asia, sometimes extending north of the Arctic Circle. In Great Britain, it is found in pastures and sand dunes, but farther south, it lives in a much wider range of habitats, including gardens. It has a blunt head and relatively short legs, and its color is very variable, although males are at their brightest during the breeding season. Sand lizards feed on small insects and spiders, and rapidly shed their tails if they are attacked, usually by snakes, birds, or mammals, especially domestic cats. Females lay clutches of 3–14 eggs in the spring and summer, and adults hibernate in winter.

REPTILES